

Regional Consultation on Artificial Intelligence Governance

Addis Ababa Declaration

We, the representatives of 22 African Member States, gathered in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia on 27th April 2026 for the Regional Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance, convened by the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia. The regional consultation was attended by 130 participants, taking part both online and in person, Attendees included UN permanent representatives of Estonia and El Salvador (co-chairs of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance), directors and representatives of resident coordinators, international organizations, academia, the private sector, civil society, the technical community, and continental organizations.

Preamble

Guided by the objectives and principles of the Constitutive Act of the African Union, which promote unity, solidarity, development, and Africa's effective participation in the global economy

Recalling Agenda 2063: The Africa We Want, adopted by the African Union as Africa's long-term strategic framework for inclusive growth, sustainable development, good governance, and global influence;

Acknowledging the Africa Digital Transformation Strategy (2020-2030) as a continental framework guiding Africa's digital future and underscoring the critical importance of aligning AI governance with its principles and priorities to ensure coherence, inclusivity, and sustainability;

Recognising that the African Union's Continental Artificial Intelligence Strategy seeks to advance a development-oriented, Africa-centric, and inclusive approach to artificial intelligence (AI), with an emphasis on building capacity, encouraging innovation, upholding ethics and human rights, and fostering regional collaboration;

Acknowledging the Science, Technology and Innovation Strategy for Africa (STISA 2034), which emphasises science, technology, innovation, and AI as critical enablers of Africa's socio-economic transformation;

Further recalling the adoption of the Global Digital Compact and the establishment of the United Nations Global Dialogue on AI Governance pursuant to United Nations General Assembly Resolution 79/325, and reaffirming Africa's commitment to constructive and meaningful engagement in this global process;

Recognising that AI is a transformative, general-purpose and specific-purpose technology with profound potential to shape Africa's economic development, employment landscape, delivery of public services, social inclusion, peace and security, as well as democratic governance across the continent;

Recognising that AI offers Africa considerable prospects for advancing structural transformation, boosting industrialisation, driving scientific progress, and fostering digital innovation, all in alignment with Agenda 2063 and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development;

Deeply concerned that unequal access to AI-related infrastructure, skills, data, and computing capacity across African countries poses a significant risk of widening existing digital, technological, and socioeconomic divides both within individual nations and between countries across the continent;

Emphasizing the universality, indivisibility, and interdependence of human rights, as well as the obligation of States to respect, protect, and promote human rights, human dignity, democracy, and the rule of law throughout all phases of the development and deployment of AI;

Emphasising also the importance of transparency, accountability, ethical conduct, and meaningful human oversight to ensure that AI serves the public interest and advances people-centred development;

Recognising the importance of regional and international cooperation, multi-stakeholder engagement, and policy coherence in shaping inclusive and interoperable AI governance frameworks;

Recognising further that advancing AI Governance supports Agenda 2063 by accelerating inclusive growth, sustainable development, good governance, human rights, people-driven progress, especially for women, youth, and the marginalised, strengthening Africa's influence globally;

Welcoming the Global Dialogue on AI Governance as a timely and inclusive platform for fostering international cooperation, sharing best practices, and advancing ethical, transparent, and sustainable approaches to artificial intelligence, while ensuring alignment with Africa's priorities under the Africa Digital Transformation Strategy (ADTS) and Agenda 2063.

Acknowledging the four core thematic clusters of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance — *Societal, Cultural, and Economic Dimensions - Bridging AI Divides-Safe and Trustworthy AI-Human Rights and Ethics* as essential pillars for ensuring a cooperative, human-centric approach to technology

DECLARE AS FOLLOWS:

1. AI opportunities and implications on African Development Priorities

Context

AI holds immense potential in unlocking opportunities for economic development in Africa. From an AI governance perspective, the inclusive adoption of AI in Africa could add as much as \$1 trillion to the African GDP by 2035, accounting for almost a third of the region's current GDP, and create 35-40 million digital jobs under full adoption.¹ AI also presents new opportunities and rapid transformations to Africa's key sectors, including finance, education, healthcare, agriculture, energy, climate change, and governance. Nevertheless, the internet connectivity and usage gap is driven by affordability, literacy, and infrastructure barriers, limiting inclusive AI adoption in Africa.

These challenges reinforce AI-related risks such as the exclusion of large segments of the population who lack access to the internet, devices, or digital skills. Related, limited AI adoption capacity also increases the risk that technological change reinforces rather than reduces inequality and benefits wealthier populations while increasing job losses, especially in labour-intensive sectors. In the absence of strategic AI governance, up to 60% of Africa's workforce is vulnerable to automation, particularly in informal and low-skilled jobs.² Africa also faces a governance gap where global AI standards are shaped externally, leaving limited influence for African stakeholders. Bridging the AI governance gap is critical to better tackle Africa's major challenges and risks (including inequality, labour market disruption, weak governance, and digital inclusion) by regulating AI systems, making them inclusive and in line with development goals under strategies such as the African Union AI strategy.

We acknowledge that an agile and appropriate governance and regulatory environment for AI plays a vital role in fostering responsible AI opportunities and establishing an observatory process aligned with African development priorities across societal, economic, and cultural aspects.

¹ African Development Bank Group. (2025, July 17). Africa's AI revolution: African Development Bank report projects \$1 trillion additional GDP by 2035 if countries use AI to enhance productivity. <https://www.afdb.org/en/news-and-events/press-releases/africas-ai-revolution-african-development-bank-report-projects-1-trillion-additional-gdp-2035-use-ai-enhance-productivity-89619>

² African Development Bank Group. (2025). Africa's AI productivity gain [Detailed report]. https://www.afdb.org/sites/default/files/documents/publications/africas_ai_productivity_gain_afdb_detailed_report_1.pdf

Call for Action:

- a) Prioritize the development of AI solutions that support structural change, increase productive employment, foster industrialisation, improve digital public services delivery, and enhance social inclusion throughout the continent.
- b) Leverage AI to boost productivity in key sectors as per national development plans while investing in skills and workforce training to prevent job displacement.
- c) Support African startups, innovators, and researchers to create locally relevant AI solutions that address African challenges and opportunities.
- d) Promote AI models that support African languages and respect cultural values and National history, ensuring accessibility and relevance across diverse communities.
- e) Advocate for the development and adoption of AI governance frameworks that are firmly rooted in Africa's unique development context, address its socioeconomic realities, and ensure its responsiveness to local institutional capacities and cultural diversity.
- f) Encourage all Member States to formulate and adopt national AI strategies that are harmonised with continental frameworks, prioritising ethics, inclusivity, particularly for rural populations, women, and youth, and sustainability.
- g) Develop regulatory sandboxes for AI governance and scalable, cross-border solutions fit for the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA).
- h) Anchor African AI development in a coherent intellectual property framework, including (a) clarification of authorship, inventorship, and ownership of AI-assisted outputs; (b) text-and-data-mining provisions that enable African AI training while protecting rights holders; (c) a continental licensing market for African datasets, models, and language resources; and (d) protection for community-driven and indigenous-language data initiatives.
- i) Advocate for global AI governance mechanisms that are open, inclusive, multistakeholder, non-prescriptive, and supportive of development, ensuring that African nations can shape diverse pathways in line with their national and regional priorities.

2. Bridging AI and Digital Divides in Africa

Context .

AI deployment across Africa has accelerated significantly over the last decade. Nevertheless, Africa contributes only about 3% of global AI talent, highlighting a major participation gap in

the global AI ecosystem.³ Africa has fewer than 40,000 AI-literate professionals, far below what is needed to support large-scale adoption.⁴ The continent faces a 32-point gap in digital skills compared to the G20 average, reflecting a major skills deficit. Only 31% of African universities offer AI programs, and 34% offer data science degrees, limiting talent development pipelines.⁵ These challenges hinder the AI adoption rate in Africa, which remains below 10% in many countries, compared to over 50% in advanced economies.⁶ In addition, the limited data centres in the continent, which are less than 1% of global data-centre capacity, constrains local AI development and deployment. This is also related to building data centres, which demand high energy and water consumption. Africa's data centre capacity (307 megawatts) is less than 2 percent of the global total, and the continent will need at least 1,200 megawatts more by 2030.⁷ Addressing these infrastructure gaps is part of Africa's AI governance.

We recognise the environmental footprint of AI compute, including energy and water consumption of data centres. Member States commit to (i) requiring Environmental and Social Impact Assessments for new data centres above a defined capacity threshold; (ii) prioritising renewable energy sources and water-recycling and outdoor-air cooling practices; and (iii) publishing annual data on AI compute energy and water use, in line with the AU's climate commitments and Agenda 2063.

Call for Action:

- a) Strengthen human capital and enhance institutional capacity in AI across Africa through promoting digital and AI literacy, , and advanced technical skills, including machine learning, data science, cybersecurity, and high-performance computing, especially for youth and women.
- b) Support universities, research institutions and technical training centres to develop AI talent pipelines across the continent
- c) Expand access to digital infrastructure, data and high-performance computing resources, with a particular focus on least developed and landlocked countries; this includes investment in digital public infrastructure, data centres and its energy sources, and interoperability standards, while supporting African-led research to enhance digital sovereignty.

³ UNESCO. (2025). AI for Africa by Africa.

https://articles.unesco.org/sites/default/files/medias/fichiers/2025/10/AI_for_Africa_by_Africa_EN.pdf

⁴ Overseas Development Institute. (2025). Brains, bytes, and bottlenecks: Fixing Africa's AI talent gap.

<https://odi.org/en/insights/brains-bytes-and-bottlenecks-fixing-africas-ai-talent-gap/>

⁵ Africa Data Centres Association. (2024, July 17). How Africa can leapfrog the world in sustainable digital infrastructure development. <https://africadca.org/en/how-africa-can-leapfrog-the-world-in-sustainable-digital-infrastructure-development/>

⁶ Business Insider Africa. (2025, October 31). AI is spreading faster than electricity or the internet — but half the world can't join in, Microsoft report says. <https://www.businessinsider.com/ai-fastest-tech-in-history-microsoft-warns-billions-left-out-2025-10>

⁷ Siren Journals (2026) https://sirenjournals.net/uploads/articles/pdfs/article_696b9386727c2.pdf

- d) Leverage the African Union, United Nations and regional mechanisms to advance and coordinate AI capacity-building efforts;
- e) Promote open-source software, open data and open AI models as public goods to stimulate innovation and entrepreneurship throughout the continent.
- f) Create a necessary Multistakeholder African and National AI sovereignty Task Force.
- g) Affirm Africa's right to access, audit, and adapt foundation models, including through public-interest compute access for African researchers and institutions, .

3. Safe, Secure and Trustworthy AI Governance

Trust is foundational to the development, adoption and impact of artificial intelligence, as it ensures that AI systems are not only safe, secure and reliable, but also uphold transparency, accountability and respect for human rights throughout their lifecycle. In Africa, the development of AI systems that are safe, secure, and trustworthy should prioritize robust risk mitigation strategies that address challenges such as misinformation, quality of data, cybersecurity threats, surveillance, and misuse.

We acknowledge the continent needs to transition from general interest to high-level policy implementation centred on the idea that trustworthy AI is not just an ethical requirement, but also a prerequisite for digital sovereignty and economic growth. Trust is foundational to the development, adoption and impact of artificial intelligence, as it ensures that AI systems are not only safe, secure and reliable, but also uphold transparency, accountability and respect for human rights throughout their lifecycle.

Call for Action:

- a) Harmonising African AI governance frameworks with developing global norms and standards, while safeguarding national and regional policy autonomy for sustainable development;
- b) Enhance policy coherence and interoperability among national and regional AI governance approaches within Africa, while preserving policy space for innovation, development, and trust in AI as a force for public good.
- c) Promote by design AI systems that are safe, secure, and trustworthy. As part of this effort, priority should be given to implementing robust risk mitigation strategies that address challenges such as misinformation, quality of data, cybersecurity threats, surveillance, and misuse.

- d) Strengthen cybersecurity readiness, incident response capabilities and resilience .
- e) Foster inclusive and transparent AI accountability mechanisms by establishing national oversight bodies, ensuring meaningful participation of all stakeholders in AI governance decision-making processes across Africa.
- f) Develop context-sensitive data governance frameworks that protect individual privacy, promote ethical data collection and use, and ensure African nations retain sovereignty over data generated on the continent, while enabling responsible cross-border data flows that support regional integration and innovation.
- g) Deploy Algorithmic Impact Assessments and Data Protection Impact Assessments of high-risk AI systems, including biometric, predictive, and automated decision-making systems
- h) Establish accessible redress mechanisms, including AI Ombudsperson functions or equivalent, that allow individuals affected by AI-driven decisions to obtain meaningful explanation, human review, correction, and remedy.

4. Respecting, protecting, and promoting human rights

Context

With AI systems continuing to advance key aspects of society's social, economic, and political life, there is a greater urgency to ensure they are developed and deployed in ways that respect human rights and protect human dignity. Despite initiatives and frameworks launched by various key stakeholders in the past, questions still remain about how these frameworks can be operationalized, harmonized, and scaled to address both global risks and national needs.

The outcome document of the WSIS+20, in its section on “human rights and ethical dimension of the information society”, acknowledges the fundamental importance of human rights in the governance of digital technologies and the implementation of the WSIS Action Lines. Issues addressed by WSIS+20 include digital inclusion and human rights challenges related to AI, online violence, data protection, and algorithmic bias. WSIS+20 reinforced that human rights must serve as a compass for new technologies and digital governance.

We recognise that AI must be governed in full compliance with international law, including international human rights law

Call for Action:

- a) Guarantee equity and inclusion in AI systems to protect the rights of women, youth, persons with disabilities, marginalized communities, and safeguard children. This includes empowering vulnerable groups through access to AI computing resources,

targeted training, digital literacy, and innovation programs to unlock opportunities in the AI era.

- b) Advance accessibility and diverse representation in AI design and development to ensure systems reflect Africa's communities.
- c) Ensure AI solutions are accountable to human control.
- d) Prevent algorithmic bias, discrimination, and exclusion by promoting fairness, representative datasets, inclusive design, and regular impact assessments.
- e) Protect privacy and personal data through robust legal, regulatory, and institutional safeguards, including secure and responsible data governance practices.
- f) Prohibit, in law, the deployment of real-time remote biometric identification in publicly accessible spaces, save where strictly necessary, proportionate, and authorised by judicial process for the investigation of serious offences, with mandatory ex-post public reporting.
- g) .Affirm that AI development on African territory shall comply with applicable labour rights, including occupational safety and mental-health protections for data-labelling and content-moderation workers, transparency of contracting and platform-mediated employment relationships, and freedom of association. Member States shall coordinate to prevent jurisdictional arbitrage by AI vendors and to require disclosure, in public procurement, of upstream labour conditions in the AI supply chain.
- h) Member States shall adopt safeguards against the use of AI to manipulate elections, generate political disinformation, or impersonate candidates, public officials, or journalists, including through synthetic media. Electoral management bodies shall be supported with technical capacity to detect and respond to AI-enabled electoral interference.
- i) AI systems directed at, or substantially affecting, children shall be subject to heightened safeguards, including age-appropriate design, restrictions on profiling and targeted advertising, parental and guardian rights, and explicit prohibitions on the use of AI in ways that exploit, sexualise, or psychologically harm children.

5. Data integrity, data collection, and data management (cross-cutting consideration)

Context

As of 2026, 76% of African countries have privacy and data-protection legislation, while the AU Malabo Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection is signed by 21

African nations and ratified by 20 countries.⁸ These progresses are crucial foundations for advancing ethical AI adoption and introduces ethical considerations.

We recognize that governments need to balance citizen protection and sovereignty with efforts to develop data systems that are inclusive, equitable, and reliable.

Call for action:

- a) Require public bodies to create, organize, and maintain data in a manner that ensures integrity and facilitates public accessibility.
- b) Public institutions should make their data accessible by default, following principles of maximum disclosure to promote transparency and public trust, in accordance with the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR/Res. 620 (LXXXI) 2024).
- c) Establish clear frameworks for regular data audits and reviews to uphold the accuracy and reliability of information used in public decision-making.
- d) Encourage the development of national and regional standards for data collection and management, focusing on ethical guidelines and best practices to strengthen data quality and public confidence.
- e) Implement continuous training programmes for public officials on data management, security, and privacy to reinforce a culture of stewardship and responsibility.
- f) Establish independent oversight mechanisms to monitor compliance with data collection, integrity, and management standards, providing avenues for public feedback and redress.
- g) maximum disclosure to promote transparency and public trust, in accordance with ACHPR/Res. 620 (LXXXI) 2024. Additionally, establish independent oversight mechanisms to monitor compliance with data collection, integrity, and management standards, providing avenues for public feedback and redress.
- h) Enhance data access for African researchers and regulators, to lower dependence on foreign tech companies to maintain information integrity;
- i) Enforce accountability on technology companies for the spread of misinformation, disinformation, and hate speech, particularly during elections and conflicts.

⁸ United Nations Conference on Trade and Development. (2026). *Summary of adoption of e-commerce legislation worldwide*. UNCTAD. <https://unctad.org/topic/ecommerce-and-digital-economy/ecommerce-law-reform/summary-adoption-e-commerce-legislation-worldwide>

6. Africa's Position and Role in the Global AI Governance

We emphasise Africa's right to meaningful and effective participation in global AI governance and norm-setting processes.

We call for global governance frameworks that:

- a) Recognise developmental asymmetries and capacity differentials
- b) Prioritise capacity-building, access, and technology cooperation
- c) Encourage interoperable and inclusive governance approaches;
- d) Strengthen African representation in multilateral institutions, technical bodies, and AI governance forums, and enhance the voice of African nations in global decision-making.
- e) Enable financial mechanisms that support the bridging of AI divides within and across African nations.
- f) Operationalise the Intellectual Property (IP) provisions of the AfCFTA IP Protocol and the AU Continental AI Strategy by establishing, through African Regional Intellectual Property Organization (ARIPO), African Intellectual Property Organization (OAPI), and national IP offices, harmonised principle-based IP guidance for AI, including administrative guidance on AI authorship and inventorship, technical infrastructures for rights reservation and licensing, and a continental approach to the protection of African language datasets used as AI training data.
- g) Operationalise dedicated financial mechanisms for AI in Africa, including the Africa AI Fund, blended-finance instruments, sovereign and pension fund participation, and Special Purpose Vehicles, with priority allocations for AI compute infrastructure, energy and water-efficient data centres, AI talent pipelines, and AI access for least-developed and landlocked countries.

6. Implementation and Way Forward

- a) The Declaration and the outcomes of the Africa Global Dialogue on AI shall be transmitted to the United Nations Global Dialogue on AI Governance as Africa's collective contribution.
- b) An Africa AI Governance Implementation Roadmap shall be developed by the African Union Commission, in consultation with Regional Economic Communities and

stakeholders, within six (6) months of adoption, with measurable targets, responsible institutions, and timelines for each commitment in this Declaration.

- c) An annual Africa AI Governance Scorecard shall be published, tracking, at minimum: status of national AI authorities; AI legislation enacted; redress and oversight mechanisms operational; biometric AI deployments and incidents; data-centre capacity and energy/water performance; AI financing disbursed; and African representation in global AI governance bodies.
- d) A successor Africa Global Dialogue on AI shall convene biennially, with a mid-cycle review at Heads of State and Government level, to assess implementation progress and update commitments.
- e) Civil society, academia, regional bodies, the private sector, and affected communities shall participate as full stakeholders in the implementation, monitoring, and review of this Declaration.
- f) Member States commit to publishing, within twelve (12) months of adoption, indicative national AI implementation budgets, including allocations for AI oversight authorities, redress mechanisms, public-interest AI research, and African-language model development.
- g) Call upon the African Development Bank, the Economic Commission for Africa, multilateral development banks, and development partners to align their AI-related financing with this Declaration and to report annually on disbursement and impact.